CONFOEDERATIO,
RESEARCH DIVISION (CRD).

THE PRINCIPALITIES OF CHERNIGOV AND NOVGOROD-SEVERSK

A Regional Literature Review of Population and Settlement (10000BC - 1300AD).

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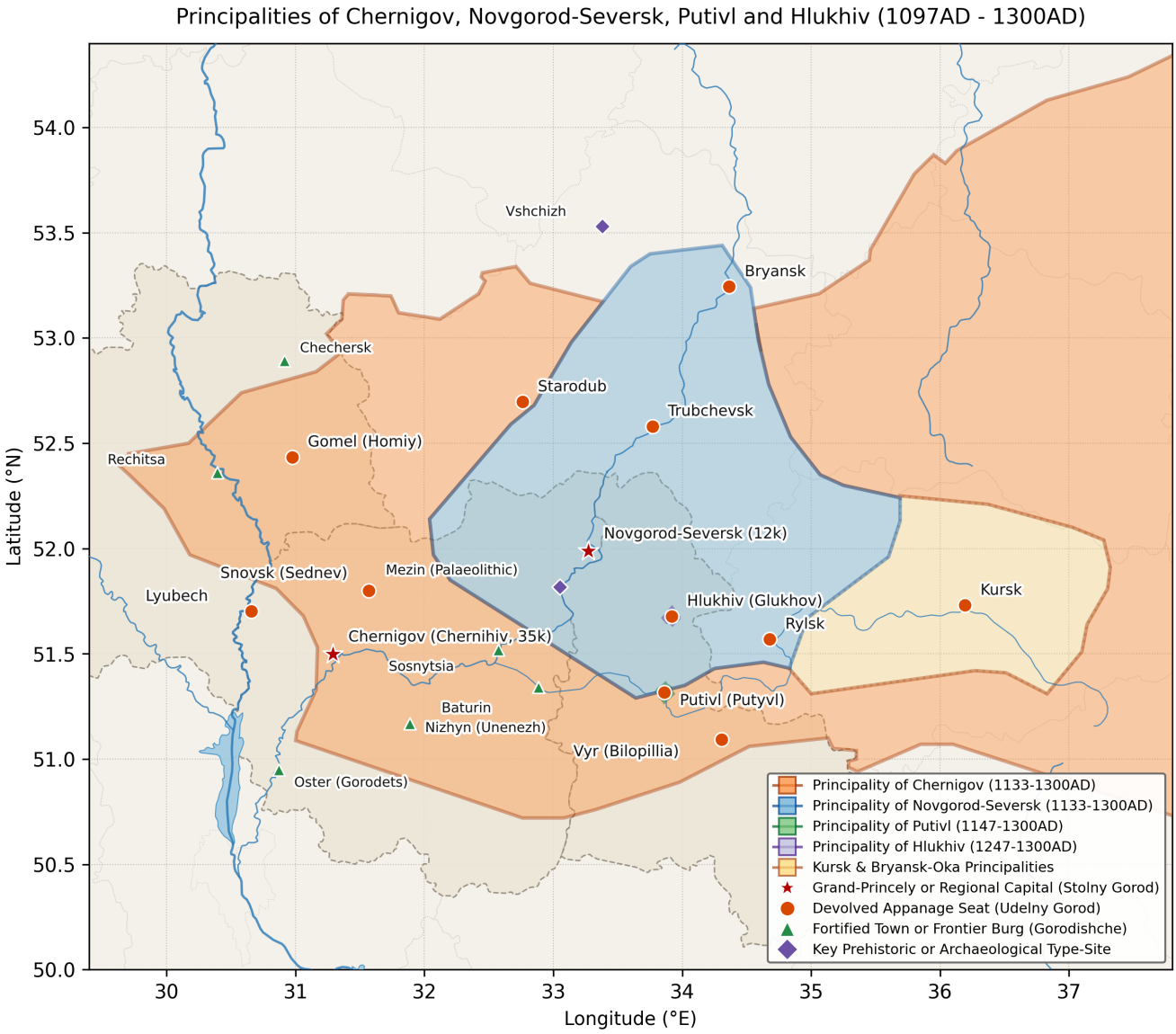


Figure 1. Regional boundaries and fortified settlements of the principalities of Chernigov, Novgorod-Seversk, Putivl, Vorgol and Hlukhiv.

Abstract

This study reconstructs the prehistoric, proto-Slavic, Kievan Rus and Mongol-era population history (10000BC - 1300AD) alongside the archaeological and chronicle settlement record for the Left-Bank Desna, Seym, Snov and Lower Sozh basins (Chernigov and Novgorod-Seversk). From the eleventh to thirteenth centuries, the wider Chernigov-Seversk realm ruled by the Olgovichi branch of the Rurikid dynasty formed the largest territorial domain in Eastern Europe, stretching from the Dnieper-Desna-Sozh river junctions in the south-west to the Upper Oka, the Moscow river approaches and the Kursk Posemye in the north-east [1][2][3].

To avoid spatial overlap across the regional demographic series, the wider Chernigov-Seversk realm is divided along modern administrative boundaries into two complementary zones. The Southern Core of Chernigov and Novgorod-Seversk (72.235 km^2) covers the dynastic capitals and southern forest-steppe heartland across Chernihivska Oblast (Ukraine, 31.903 km^2), Sumska Oblast (Ukraine, 23.832 km^2) and the Eastern Gomel and Lower Sozh-Dnieper Corridor (Belarus, 16.500 km^2). This area encompasses the primary domains of the Principality of Chernigov, the Principality of Novgorod-Seversk, the Principality of Putivl, the Principality of Vorgol and the post-Mongol Principality of Hlukhiv. The Northern Russian Half (~118.000 km^2) covers the northern forest and north-eastern forest-steppe appanages inside the modern Russian Federation, accounted for separately in the Russian Core review across the Upper Oka and Bryansk-Chernigov North (Bryansk, Starodub, Trubchevsk, Vshchizh, Karachev, Novosil, Tarusa, Mtsensk, Odoev, Vorotynsk, Belyov and Kozelsk) and the Kursk-Seversk Steppe Frontier (Kursk, Rylsk and Yelets).

At the 1200AD pre-Mongol peak, the Southern Core supported 460.000 inhabitants (360.000 - 560.000, mean density 6,37 inh/km^2), anchored by the urban complex of Chernigov (35.000 inhabitants across 330 ha) and the princely seats of Novgorod-Seversk (12.000), Putivl (7.500), Gomel (5.000) and Hlukhiv (5.000) [4][5][6]. Combined with the 500.000 inhabitants estimated for the Northern Russian Half (210.000 in Bryansk-Starodub-Upper Oka plus 290.000 in Kursk-Rylsk Posemye), the Grand Principality of Chernigov-Seversk as a whole contained 960.000 inhabitants in 1200AD, rivalled within the Rus lands only by the combined Kievan-Galician-Volhynian south [7]. Following the October 1239AD Mongol invasion under Mengu-Timur, the Southern Core contracted by 54,3% to 210.000 in 1250AD before recovering to 260.000 by 1300AD under the sheltered post-conquest principalities of Hlukhiv, Putivl and post-Mongol Chernigov.

Table 1 summarises the population series for the Southern Core (72.235 km^2) across sixteen benchmarks (n=16) from the Late Pleniglacial and Bølling-Allerød mammoth-hunter camps to the post-Mongol principalities at 1300AD.

Epoch	Best Estimate	Uncertainty Band	Density (inh/km2)	Urban Share (%)	Primary Evidentiary Basis
10000BC	4.500	2.500 - 7.500	0,06	0%	Mezin, Pushkari I & Chulatovo mammoth-bone camps
6000BC	9.000	5.500 - 14.000	0,12	0%	Desna-Sozh Mesolithic & early Pit-Comb Ware sites
4000BC	18.000	11.000 - 27.000	0,25	0%	Dnieper-Donets II & Desna Neolithic fishers
1500BC	52.000	34.000 - 74.000	0,72	0%	Sosnytsia & Marianivka Bronze Age agro-pastoralists
500BC	85.000	55.000 - 120.000	1,18	0%	Yukhnovo, Milograd & Scythian Posemye hillforts

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Epoch	Best Estimate	Uncertainty Band	Density (inh/km2)	Urban Share (%)	Primary Evidentiary Basis
0AD	105.000	70.000 - 145.000	1,45	0%	Late Zarubintsy (Pochep-Harivka) & Late Scythian
300AD	140.000	95.000 - 190.000	1,94	0%	Kiev culture (Roishche) & northern Chernyakhov peak
500AD	115.000	75.000 - 160.000	1,59	0%	Kolochin culture forest-riverine refugia
700AD	165.000	115.000 - 220.000	2,28	2,5%	Volyntsevo & early Romny-Borshchevo Severian opoliya
800AD	190.000	135.000 - 250.000	2,63	4,8%	Bititsa, Gornal & Romny fortified Severian hillforts
900AD	220.000	160.000 - 285.000	3,05	8,5%	Shestovytsia, Chernigov barrows & Lyubech trade axis
1000AD	280.000	210.000 - 355.000	3,88	13,2%	Early Rurikid tribute network & Severian integration
1100AD	365.000	285.000 - 450.000	5,05	17,8%	Post-1097AD Lyubech Congress Olgovichi expansion
1200AD	460.000	360.000 - 560.000	6,37	21,5%	Olgovichi apogee (116 hillforts; Chernigov 35k)
1250AD	210.000	155.000 - 275.000	2,91	10,5%	October 1239AD Mongol destruction of Desna-Posemye
1300AD	260.000	195.000 - 330.000	3,6	11,8%	Post-Mongol Hlukhiv, Putivl & Chernigov principalities

Table 1. Population, settlement density and urban share in the southern Chernigov-Seversk core (10000BC - 1300AD).

Background

The political geography of the Left-Bank Desna, Seym, Snov and Lower Sozh basin reflects the dynastic division of the Olgovichi (descendants of Oleg Svyatoslavich, d. 1115AD, who secured hereditary rights to the Chernigov land at the Congress of Lyubech in 1097AD) [2][3]. Following Vsevolod Olgovich's accession to the Kievan throne (1139AD), the realm divided into the senior Chernigov patrimony (*Otchina*) along the Lower and Middle Desna, Snov and Sozh, and the junior Seversk (*Sever*) patrimony along the Middle Desna and Seym. After the Mongol sack of 1239AD and the execution of Grand Prince Mikhail Vsevolodovich at the Golden Horde (1246AD), the southern lands reorganised into the post-Mongol principalities of Chernigov, Novgorod-Seversk, Putivl and Hlukhiv (founded 1247AD). Table 2 lists the principalities within the Southern Core territory.

Dynastic Phase	Principality Name	Active Span	Capital (Coords)	Core Basin & Administrative Coverage
Senior Patrimony	Principality of Chernigov	1133-1279AD	Chernigov (51,5°N, 31,29°E)	Lower & Middle Desna, Snov, Oster & Lower Sozh (Chernihiv & Gomel)
Post-Mongol Core	Principality of Chernigov	1279-1356AD	Chernigov (51,5°N, 31,29°E)	Post-Mongol Desna-Snov-Sozh core under Bryansk-Chernigov line
Late Appanage	Principality of Chernigov	1356-1358AD	Chernigov (51,5°N, 31,29°E)	Late post-Mongol Chernigov domain prior to Lithuanian annexation
Seversk Patrimony	Principality of Novgorod-Seversk	1133-1363AD	Novgorod-Seversk (51,99°N, 33,27°E)	Middle Desna, Lower Seym & Ivot-Esman (NE Chernihiv & N Sumy)
Posemye Appanage	Principality of Putivl	1147-1501AD	Putivl (51,32°N, 33,86°E)	Middle Seym (Posemye), Vyr, Kleven & Upper Sula & Psyol (Sumy)
Kleven Appanage	Principality of Vorgol	1203-1241AD	Vorgol (51,48°N, 33,78°E)	Kleven-Seym interfluve NW of Putivl (Krolevets & Putyvl)
Esman-Kleven Refuge	Principality of Hlukhiv	1247-1408AD	Hlukhiv (51,68°N, 33,92°E)	Post-Mongol Esman-Kleven plateau (Hlukhiv & Yampil)

Table 2. Devolved Rurikid principalities, chronological spans, capitals and river basins in the southern Chernigov-Seversk lands.

Methodology

Because historical and archaeological studies by A. K. Zaitsev [1], V. P. Kovalenko [4], A. V. Kuza [6][8] and M. Dimnik [3] often cite aggregate figures for the entire Chernigov-Seversk realm from the Desna mouth to the Upper Oka and Kursk Posemye, separate accounting is needed to link this Southern Core study with the Northern Russian appanages documented in the European Russia regional review.

In the northern and north-eastern wings of the Olgovichi patrimony, the Upper Oka and Bryansk-Chernigov North (~70.000 km^2) covers modern Bryansk, Kaluga, Orel and western Tula Oblasts, comprising Bryansk, Starodub, Trubchevsk, Vshchizh, Karachev, Novosil, Tarusa, Mtsensk, Odoev, Vorotynsk, Belyov and Kozelsk. Following the 1239AD sack of southern Chernigov, Prince Roman Mikhailovich transferred the senior Chernigov-Bryansk throne northward into the Bryansk forest (*Debryansk*), initiating a lasting population shift toward the wooded Upper Oka (*Verchovskie*) principalities. To the south-east, the Kursk-Seversk Steppe Frontier (~48.000 km^2) covers modern Kursk and western Lipetsk and Belgorod Oblasts, comprising Kursk, Rylsk and Yelets along the Tuskar, Upper Seym, Svapa and Upper Psyol rivers.

Table 3 shows how the four sub-regions of the Southern Core (Chernigov Core, Novgorod-Seversk, Putivl-Vorgol-Hlukhiv and Lower Sozh and Gomel) combine with the northern Upper Oka and Kursk-Rylsk appanages to reconstruct the population of the wider Chernigov-Seversk lands (800AD - 1300AD) without boundary overlap.

Sub-Region/Devolved Principality Division	800AD	1000AD	1100AD	1200AD	1250AD	1300AD
Chernigov Core (Desna-Snov-Oster)	100.000	150.000	195.000	240.000	100.000	130.000
Novgorod-Seversk (Middle Desna)	30.000	42.000	55.000	70.000	35.000	42.000
Putivl, Vorgol & Hlukhiv (Posemye)	26.000	38.000	50.000	70.000	35.000	38.000
Lower Sozh & Dnieper (Gomel Corridor)	34.000	50.000	65.000	80.000	40.000	50.000
Southern Core Subtotal (72.235 km2)	190.000	280.000	365.000	460.000	210.000	260.000
Bryansk, Starodub & Upper Oka North	90.000	130.000	170.000	210.000	120.000	140.000
Kursk & Rylsk Posemye East	100.000	150.000	200.000	290.000	100.000	120.000
Northern Appanages Subtotal (118.000 km2)	190.000	280.000	370.000	500.000	220.000	260.000
Grand Principality of Chernigov-Seversk Total	380.000	560.000	735.000	960.000	430.000	520.000

Table 3. Sub-regional population estimates across the southern Chernigov-Seversk principalities and northern Russian appanages (800 - 1300AD).

Results

Prehistoric and Early Slavic Settlement (10000BC - 1000AD)

Upper Palaeolithic to Bronze Age (10000BC - 1000BC)

The middle Desna chalk gorge between Pushkari, Novgorod-Seversk and Mezin (Mizyn) formed one of the main Upper Palaeolithic periglacial refugia in Eurasia [9][10][11]. At Mezin (51,83°N, 33,08°E), I. G. Shovkoplyas excavated five circular mammoth-bone *yaranga*-type dwellings (n=5) enclosing hearths fuelled by bone ash, marine amber ornaments transported over 600 km and geometric meander-engraved ivory bracelets dated to the late Pleniglacial and Bølling-Allerød transition (13000BC - 10000BC). Directly upstream along the Desna bluffs, Pushkari I (Pogon), Chulatovo I-II, Buzhany and the Novgorod-Seversky rock-shelter document multi-family winter aggregation camps of 60 to 120 inhabitants each. Across the 72.235 km^2 regional core, the 10000BC Late Palaeolithic population is estimated at 4.500 inhabitants (2.500 - 7.500, 0,06 inh/km^2).

During the Holocene climatic optimum (6000BC - 3000BC), Mesolithic hunter-fishers of the Desna-Sozh tradition gave way to the Dnieper-Donets II and Pit-Comb Ware Neolithic cultures, occupying low sandy river terraces along the Desna, Snov, Seym and Sozh (9.000 inhabitants at 6000BC, rising to 18.000 by

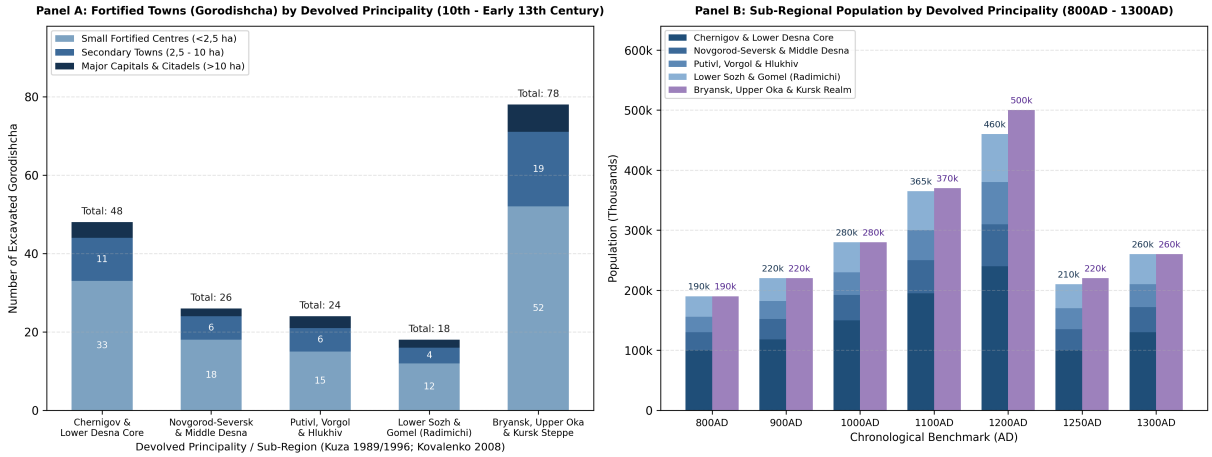


Figure 2. Fortified settlement hierarchy by rampart area and sub-regional population across the Chernigov-Seversk principalities (800 - 1300AD).

4000BC). In the Middle and Late Bronze Age (2000BC - 1000BC), the Sosnytsia variant of the Trzciniec-Komariv complex and the Marianivka culture along the Seym introduced mixed millet-barley cultivation and floodplain cattle pastoralism, raising the regional population to 52.000 at 1500BC (0,72 inh/km^2) [12].

Yukhnovo, Milograd, Kiev and Kolochin Horizons (1000BC - 700AD)

In the Early Iron Age (700BC - 200BC), the region was divided between two fortified hillfort cultures that established the promontory settlement network of the Desna and Sozh basins [12][13]. The Yukhnovo Culture (named after the Yukhnovo type-hillfort near Novgorod-Seversk) occupied the Middle Desna and Seym valleys, constructing timber-laced earthen ramparts on high right-bank chalk headlands (0,5 - 2,5 ha per hillfort, housing 60 - 150 inhabitants at sites such as Kurove-Yukhnovo, Khorobor, Ponornytsia and Novgorod-Seversk). To the west, the Milograd Culture (named after the Milograd hillfort on the Dnieper south of Rechitsa) occupied the Lower Sozh, Braginka and Dnieper-Desna interfluve (Gomel, Khalch, Milograd, Lyubech and Gorval), while Scythian forest-steppe farmers fortified the Upper Sula, Psyol and Vorskla valleys (Vovkivtsi, Pustoviitivka, Kuzemyn and Romny). By 500BC, regional population reached 85.000 (1,18 inh/km^2).

During the Late La Tène and Roman Iron Age (200BC - 400AD), Late Zarubintsy (Pochep-Harivka horizon, 105.000 at 0AD) and Kiev culture (200AD - 450AD, excavated at Roishche, Desna-Harivka and Ulianyky) unfortified riverside hamlets spread along the Desna, Snov and Lower Sozh, while the northernmost Chernyakhov culture settlements reached the Sula, Psyol and southern Seym, supporting a Roman-era peak of 140.000 inhabitants at 300AD (1,94 inh/km^2) [14][15]. Following the Hunnic collapse of the Chernyakhov frontier in the late fourth century, the early Slavic Kolochin culture (450AD - 700AD, named after the Kolochin I promontory hillfort near Rechitsa) consolidated along the wooded Dnieper-Sozh-Desna valleys, supporting 115.000 inhabitants at 500AD (1,59 inh/km^2) [15][16].

Severian Expansion and Shestovytsia (700AD - 1000AD)

In the eighth and ninth centuries, Slavic population growth accelerated under the Volyntsevo culture (700AD - 820AD, named after the type-site near Putivl, alongside the fortified Khazar-Severian administrative citadel at Bytytsia on the Psyol) and its successor, the Romny-Borshchevo culture (800AD - 1000AD, named after the *Monastyryshche* hillfort at Romny on the Sula) [13][17][18]. Identified with the chronicle Severians (*Severyane*) on the Desna, Seym and Sula and the southern Radimichi on the Lower Sozh, the Romny population combined fortified promontory refuges (Novotroitske, Gornal, Putivl, Vyr, Romny, Chernigov, Snovsk and Gomel) with dense clusters of open *selyshcha* equipped with sunken-featured dwellings (*poluzemlyanki*) and domed clay ovens. Archaeological surveys by O. V. Sukhobokov record over 320 Volyntsevo and Romny settlements (n=320) across the Southern Core, supporting 165.000 inhabitants by 700AD, 190.000 by 800AD and 220.000 by 900AD.

At the same time, the Lower Desna and Dnieper-Sozh corridor became a major artery of Varangian-Rus trade and military organisation [19][20][21]. At Shestovytsia (Korovel, 18 km south-west of Chernigov), excavations by P. Smolychev, D. I. Blifeld, V. P. Kovalenko and O. P. Motsia revealed a 16 ha fortified hillfort and harbour suburb accompanied by five barrow cemeteries (exceeding 400 mounds, n=5) containing tenth-century Scandinavian chamber graves with Frankish swords, warhorses, folding balances and Abbasid and Samanid silver dirhams (2.400 inhabitants in 900AD, peaking at 3.200 in 1000AD). In the Chernigov retinue necropolises (Chorna Mohyla, Hulbyshche and Boldyni Hory), B. A. Rybakov's study of the *Chorna Mohyla* princely tumulus (40 m diameter, 11 m height, c. 960AD) and the more than 230 barrows (n=230) of Boldyni Hory shows that tenth-century Chernigov already functioned as the seat of an autonomous princely and boyar *druzhina* (9.500 inhabitants in 900AD, rising to 18.000 by 1000AD). Further west, Lyubech (51,7°N, 30,66°E) and Mokhov (52,02°N, 30,73°E) guarded the Dnieper-Sozh-Desna confluence; Lyubech is listed by Constantine Porphyrogenitus (*De Administrando Imperio*, c. 948AD) as *Telioutza*, one of the fortified ship-assembly stations on the route from the Varangians to the Greeks (3.500 at Lyubech and 1.950 at Mokhov in 1000AD).

By 1000AD, following Grand Prince Vladimir Svyatoslavich's integration of the Severian and Radimichi lands (984AD Battle on the Pishchana) and the construction of the Desna-Oster-Sula frontier ramparts (Gorodets Ostersky, Pryluky, Romny and Vovkivtsi), the Southern Core reached 280.000 inhabitants (3,88 inh/km^2), with an urban population of 37.000 (13,2%).

The Olgovichi Principalities (1000AD - 1239AD)

Dynastic Consolidation (1024AD - 1239AD)

Following the Battle of Listven (1024AD, fought beside the Listven hillfort 22 km north of Chernigov), Prince Mstislav Vladimirovich established Chernigov as the capital of Left-Bank Rus, founding the stone Transfiguration Cathedral (*Spaso-Preobrazhensky Sobor*, 1030-1036AD) inside the 16 ha *Detinets* [2][19]. Under Svyatoslav Yaroslavich (1054-1076AD) and his son Oleg Svyatoslavich (d. 1115AD), recognised at the Congress of Lyubech (1097AD) as hereditary ruler of the Chernigov-Seversk land, the dynasty promoted internal colonisation across the *Chernigov Opolye*, the middle Desna, the Lower Sozh and the Posemye steppe frontier [1][3].

Archaeological surveys by V. P. Kovalenko [4], A. V. Kuza [6][8], P. P. Tolochko [5], Yu. Yu. Morgunov [22] and H. V. Shtykhov [23] catalogue 116 excavated tenth- to early thirteenth-century fortified *gorodishcha* (n=116) within the Southern Core (48 in the Chernigov Core, 26 in Novgorod-Seversk, 24 in Putivl-Vorgol-Hlukhiv and 18 in the Lower Sozh and Gomel corridor), plus 78 *gorodishcha* (n=78) in the northern Russian appanages (194 fortified towns in total across the Grand Principality), surrounded by over 2.100 unfortified rural *selyshcha* (such as the excavated 12 ha rural craft village of Avtunichi).

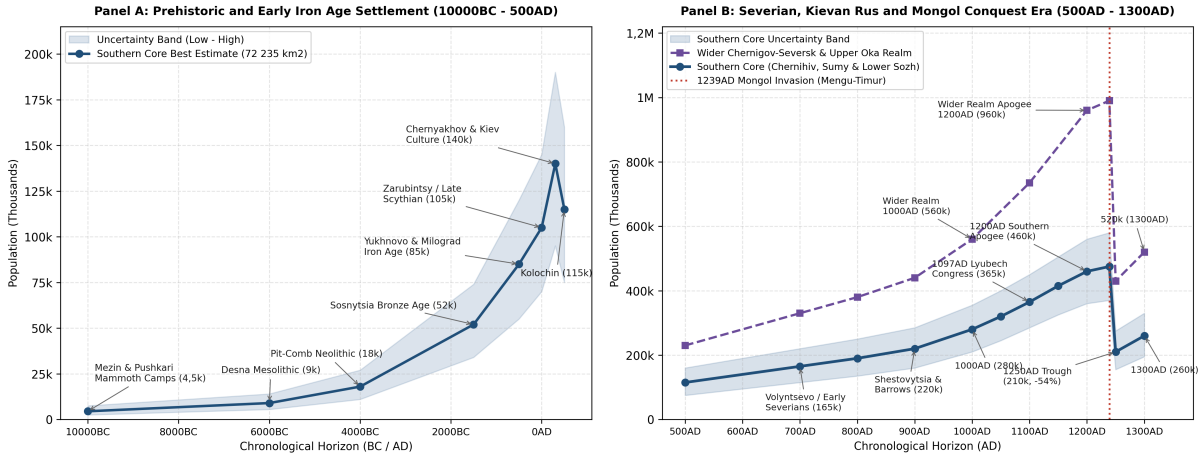


Figure 3. Prehistoric and medieval population of the Left-Bank Desna, Seym, Snov and Lower Sozh basins from 10000BC to 1300AD.

Urban Hierarchy (1200AD)

Applying the Rus urban archaeological multipliers of P. P. Tolochko and A. V. Kuza (120 - 150 inh/ha for densely built *detinets* and *okolny gorod* ramparts; 75 - 100 inh/ha for outer *posad* and *podol* craft quarters, corresponding to 20 - 25 homesteads per hectare at 5,5 - 6 persons per household), Table 4 details the 1200AD urban hierarchy across the Southern Core and key northern centres.

Urban Centre	Rampart (ha)	Posad (ha)	Total (ha)	1200AD Pop.	1250AD Pop.
Chernigov	160 ha	170 ha	330 ha	35.000	5.000
Novgorod-Seversk	32 ha	43 ha	75 ha	12.000	3.800
Putivl	22 ha	23 ha	45 ha	7.500	3.200
Gomel (Homiy)	18 ha	24 ha	42 ha	5.000	2.800
Hlukhiv	15 ha	17 ha	32 ha	5.000	4.000
Lyubech	14 ha	16 ha	30 ha	4.500	2.100
Vyr	15 ha	20 ha	35 ha	4.500	800
Romny (Romen)	12 ha	16 ha	28 ha	4.200	1.500
Snovsk (Sedniv)	12 ha	12 ha	24 ha	4.000	1.200
Oster	10 ha	12 ha	22 ha	3.500	1.400
Pryluky	10 ha	11 ha	21 ha	3.200	1.100
Vsevolozh	10 ha	10 ha	20 ha	3.000	600
Vorgol	9 ha	11 ha	20 ha	3.000	700
Bragin	9 ha	11 ha	20 ha	3.000	1.400
Khorobor	9 ha	9 ha	18 ha	2.800	900
Unenezh (Nizhyn)	9 ha	9 ha	18 ha	2.800	950
Sosnytsia	9 ha	9 ha	18 ha	2.800	1.150
Rechitsa	8 ha	8 ha	16 ha	2.500	1.500
Kursk (Posemye East)	24 ha	31 ha	55 ha	8.000	2.200
Bryansk (Upper Desna)	20 ha	20 ha	40 ha	6.000	6.500
Starodub (Seversk North)	16 ha	18 ha	34 ha	5.000	2.400

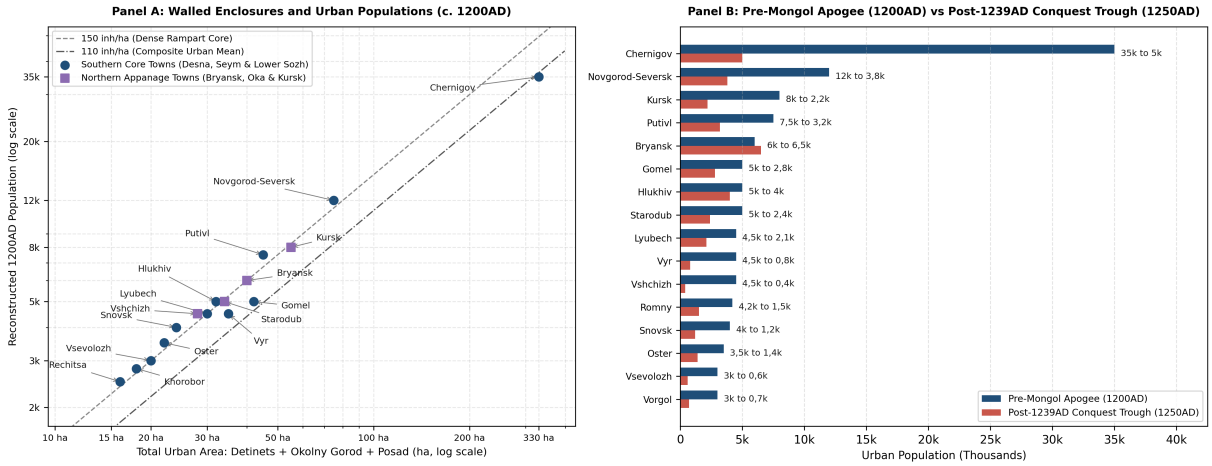


Figure 4. Fortified enclosure areas and pre-Mongol versus post-conquest urban populations across the principal towns of Chernigov-Seversk (1200 - 1250AD).

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Urban Centre	Rampart (ha)	Posad (ha)	Total (ha)	1200AD Pop.	1250AD Pop.
Vshchizh (Upper Desna)	14 ha	14 ha	28 ha	4.500	400

Table 4. Fortified rampart areas, suburban posad extents and estimated urban populations of major Chernigov-Seversk towns (1200 - 1250AD).

Sub-Regional Population at 1200AD (460.000 Inhabitants)

Within the Principality of Chernigov Core (240.000 inhabitants at 1200AD), settlement centred on the fertile *Chernigov Opolye* between the Desna, Snov and Bilous rivers (12 - 18 inh/km^2), where princely domains (*sela*) such as Orgoshch (2.100), Listven (1.850), Blestovit (2.000), Gurichev (1.800), Snovsk (4.000) and Berezna (2.200) supplied grain, warhorses and ironwork to the 35.000-strong capital of Chernigov (16 ha *Detinets*, 40 ha *Okolny Gorod*, 20 ha *Tretyak*, 85 ha walled *Peredgorodier* and 170 ha *Podol* and *Leskovitsa* craft suburbs, containing five twelfth- and early thirteenth-century brick cathedrals: the Transfiguration, Boris and Gleb, Dormition at Yeletsky Monastery, St Elias and St Paraskeva Pyatnitsa) [4][19]. Along the Dnieper, middle Desna and Oster-Udai corridors, fortified *volost* centres - Lyubech (4.500, where B. A. Rybakov excavated the timber-and-earth princely castle of *Zamkova Hora*), Oster (3.500), Pryluky (3.200), Vsevolozh (3.000), Sosnytsia (2.800), Khorobor (2.800), Unenezh (Nizhyn, 2.800), Baturin (2.600), Bakhmach (2.400), Moroviisk (2.200), Varva (2.100) and Lutava (1.800) - anchored an urban network of 68.000 townspeople (28,3% of the core's population) and 172.000 rural inhabitants [1].

In the Principality of Novgorod-Seversk along the Middle Desna and Ivot-Esman tributaries (70.000 inhabitants at 1200AD), administration was conducted from the high chalk headland of Novgorod-Seversk (12.000 inhabitants across 75 ha, comprising the 2,5 ha *Zamkova Hora* citadel, the 30 ha *Okolny Gorod* and the stone Spaso-Preobrazhensky princely monastery). Celebrated as the seat of Prince Igor Svyatoslavich (1151-1202AD) in the *Tale of Igor's Campaign* (1185AD), this principality controlled the middle Desna crossings and the wooded Ivot, Znob and Esman valleys, including Voronizh (2.400), Krolevets-Retezh

(1.100), Znob (950), Shalyhyne-Obesta (850), Ivot (780), Yampil (740) and Kurove-Yukhnovo (720) [3][4].

Across the Principalities of Putivl, Vorgol and Hlukhiv in the Posemye and Upper Sula and Psyol valleys (70.000 inhabitants at 1200AD), a chain of fortresses guarded the southern forest-steppe frontier against the Polovtsians (*Cumans*). Putivl (7.500 inhabitants across 45 ha, with a twelfth-century brick princely church excavated on *Nikolske Gorka*) formed a fortified network with Vyr (4.500 across 35 ha), Hlukhiv (5.000 across 32 ha), Romny (4.200 across 28 ha) and Vorgol (3.000 across 20 ha, seat of an autonomous appanage on the Kleven cliffs between 1203AD and 1241AD) [18][22]. Secondary steppe-watch fortresses along the Seym, Tern, Sula, Psyol and Vorskla included Lipen (Sumy, 2.600), Okhtyrka (2.500), Hlinsk (2.300), Popash (2.200), Konotop (2.100), Viakhan (2.100), Zartyi (1.900), Lipovets (1.850), Nedryhailiv (1.350) and Igoreve Seltsye (1.250, the fortified princely estate with wine and honey cellars looted in the 1146AD chronicle).

In the Lower Sozh and Dnieper-Braginka Corridor of eastern Gomel (80.000 inhabitants at 1200AD), which incorporated the southern Radimichi and Dregovichi-Severian contact zone under Chernigov rule, the riverine settlement network was anchored by Gomel (*Homiy*, 5.000 inhabitants across 42 ha, with weapon-smithing workshops excavated by O. A. Makushnykov), Bragin (3.000), Rechitsa (2.500), Chechersk (2.300), Loyev (2.200), Khalch (1.450), Streshin (1.250), Gorval (1.150) and Zaspa (1.050) [23][24].

Mongol Invasion and Post-Conquest Era (1239AD - 1300AD)

Destruction of October 1239AD

In the autumn of 1239AD, following the campaigns against Ryazan (1237AD), Vladimir-Suzdal (1238AD) and Pereyaslavl-Yuzhny (March 1239AD), a Mongol army commanded by Batu's cousin Mengu-Timur (Möngke) and Kadan advanced up the Seym and Desna valleys against the Chernigov-Seversk principalities [3][4]. Archaeological excavations across more than forty *gorodishcha* (n=40) in the Southern Core reveal a mid-thirteenth-century destruction layer marked by vitrified timber-and-earth ramparts, clusters of armour-piercing Mongol tanged arrowheads, hoards of silver *grivnas* and temple rings and unburied skeletons in collapsed dwellings and church vaults.

Along the Posemye corridor, Putivl, Vyr, Vorgol, Hlukhiv, Popash and Viakhan were stormed during the autumn offensive along the Seym and Kleven in October 1239AD. At Putivl and Vyr, mass graves containing decapitated and arrow-pierced defenders alongside burned artisan quarters record the loss of the frontier garrisons [18], while Vorgol, Popash, Viakhan and Zartyi suffered destruction and permanent urban abandonment after 1239-1241AD. Along the Desna-Snov-Oster approach, Snovsk, Sosnytsia, Khorobor, Vsevolozh, Unenezh, Orgoshch, Listven and Blestovit were sacked to sever communications before the investment of Chernigov; at Vsevolozh, Blestovit and Unenezh, burned rampart casemates yielded hundreds of skeletons of defenders, women and children who perished in the flames [4].

During the siege and sack of Chernigov on 18 October 1239AD, as recorded in the Laurentian and Hypatian Chronicles, Mongol siege engineers surrounded the city and bombarded the walls with heavy counterweight trebuchets (*poroki*) that hurled stones a distance of a bowshot and a half, each stone requiring four men to lift. Despite a relief sortie led outside the ramparts by Prince Mstislav Glebovich of Rylsk and Chernigov - whose troops were routed in open battle - the Mongols breached the *Okolny Gorod* on 18 October 1239AD, put the city to the torch, looted the five brick cathedrals and slaughtered or enslaved the population [3][4]. Excavations across the 170 ha *Peredgorodier* and *Podol* show that the outer suburbs ceased to be occupied, leaving post-conquest settlement confined to the 16 ha *Detinets* (~5.000 inhabitants in 1250AD).

Post-Mongol Realignment (1240AD - 1300AD)

Between 1239AD and 1250AD, the population of the Southern Core fell by 54,3%, dropping from 460.000 (1200AD) to 210.000 (1250AD, 2,91 inh/km^2), while the urban share declined from 21,5% to 10,5%. Over 65% of the 116 fortified *gorodishcha* in the Southern Core ceased to function as urban settlements. Following the execution of Grand Prince Mikhail Vsevolodovich of Chernigov and his boyar Fedor at the Golden Horde in September 1246AD for refusing to walk between purification fires [3], the political and settlement geography of the Chernigov-Seversk lands underwent a three-way realignment between 1246AD and 1300AD.

Under Mikhail's younger son Roman Mikhailovich the Old (1246-1288AD), the senior princely seat moved from Chernigov northward into the forests of Bryansk, which grew from 6.000 (1200AD) to 6.500 (1250AD). Even so, Chernigov, Lyubech (2.500 in 1300AD) and the Lower Sozh towns (Gomel at 3.400, Rechitsa at 1.900, Bragin at 1.750 and Chechersk at 1.650) retained a reduced episcopal and princely administration, supporting 130.000 inhabitants in the Chernigov Core and 50.000 in the Lower Sozh by 1300AD [24][25].

In 1247AD, Mikhail Vsevolodovich's second son Simeon Mikhailovich established an autonomous hereditary principality at Hlukhiv (1247-1408AD) on the wooded Esman-Kleven plateau (51,68°N, 33,92°E). Sheltered by marshy forests north of the steppe corridor, Hlukhiv retained 4.000 inhabitants in 1250AD and 4.500 in 1300AD, serving as the main urban refuge in the southern Seversk lands until the mid-fourteenth century.

Meanwhile, descendants of the Igorichi line maintained the Principality of Putivl (3.200 inhabitants in 1250AD, recovering to 3.800 by 1300AD) alongside Novgorod-Seversk (3.800 in 1250AD, 4.500 in 1300AD) and Romny (1.950 in 1300AD). Under Golden Horde suzerainty, the Posemye was supervised by the Mongol *baskak* Akhmad, whose creation of tax-exempt *slobody* near Lipovets and Vorgol provoked the 1283-1285AD uprising of Princes Oleg of Rylsk-Vorgol and Svyatoslav of Lipovets recorded in the Laurentian Chronicle [18][25]. By 1300AD, natural recovery across these wooded riverine valleys restored the Southern Core to 260.000 inhabitants (3,6 inh/km^2), while the wider Chernigov-Seversk realm (including the northern Russian appanages) stood at 520.000 inhabitants.

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